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How ironic that Iga Swiatek ended her longest title drought on her worst surface at the most prestigious tournament. Even more surprising, one-time teen phenom Amanda Anisimova also revitalised her career by reaching her first Grand Slam final.

These feel-good stories highlighted a fortnight that started with an unprecedented 17 of 32 ladies' singles seeds eliminated by the second round and ended with a different champion for the eighth straight time since Serena Williams in 2016.

Even though *IBM Insights* gave Swiatek — a five-time Major winner — a 69 per cent chance of winning, her 6-0, 6-0 demolition of Anisimova was yet another stunner in the 'expect the unexpected' world of women's tennis.

It was the worst shellacking in a Major final since all-time great Steffi Graf 'double-bageled' Natalia Zvereva in a 31-minute yawner at the 1988 French Open and the most lopsided match at Wimbledon since 1911, when Dorothea Lambert Chambers shut out Dora Boothby 6-0, 6-0.

Suffering from stage fright, Anisimova dropped eight of the first 10 points to fall behind 2-0 quickly. If the final had a critical juncture — at least for the tall (5'11"), hard-hitting American — it was the third game. Anisimova built a 40-15 lead and had four chances to hold serve. Alas, a Swiatek backhand winner, along with two unforced backhand errors and an unforced forehand error by Anisimova, squandered those chances before a double fault gave the game to Swiatek.

The champion completed the Saturday afternoon massacre on Centre Court with a backhand winner down the line. The demoralised runner-up didn't even run for the ball. "Iga was hitting everything [well]. She

played flawlessly," said *ESPN* analyst and former superstar Chris Evert. Indeed, Swiatek had a staggering 55-24 advantage in total points won, as she smacked 29 winners against only 11 unforced errors.

The evolution of Swiatek is a tribute to her dedication and her closely knit team — the astute coaching of Wim Fissette (who previously guided Kim Clijsters, Victoria Azarenka, Simona Halep, Angelique Kerber, and Naomi Osaka), the support of her longtime sports psychologist Daria Abramowicz, fitness trainer Maciej Ryszczyk, and hitting partner Tomek Moczek. "I feel they believed in me more than I did," Swiatek said during the trophy ceremony.

After the undisputed Queen of Clay — she won four Roland Garros crowns this decade — failed to capture a title on clay this spring, she added power to her serve, flattened her Western forehand a bit, and became more comfortable moving on slick grass. It paid off. She made her first final on grass at the tune-up tournament in Bad Homburg.

After notching a 6-2, 7-5 victory over Russian veteran Liudmila Samsonova to reach the semifinals, a career-best showing at The Championships, Swiatek said, "I feel like I'm doing a great job at just learning how to play on grass. [It's the] first time I feel more comfortable. I feel like the process has some kind of logic."

Her learning curve accelerated in the last two rounds. Against Belinda Bencic, a 66-1 long shot who missed Wimbledon last year while on maternity leave, Swiatek completely dominated from start to finish, racing to a 6-2, 6-0 victory. Using her powerful first serve that peaked at 8.9 on the Serve Quality rating to complement her terrific forehand, Swiatek has developed a formidable serve-plus-one, quick-strike weapon that proved especially effective on grass. Once vulnerable to power hitters like Elena Rybakina, Aryna Sabalenka, Clara Tauson, Linda Noskova, and Danielle Collins, the 5'9" Pole now has the firepower to combat them.